

Chapter 58-1

The office was silent.

No one understood why Liang Shi had said that. Liang Xinhe frowned and asked, "What do you mean?"

"She'll continue to stoke the fire," Liang Shi said. "The information I'm revealing to her now is that we have no leverage here. That day in the restroom, there were only the three of them, and only Bai Weiwei recorded the video. There's also no surveillance in the restroom, so as long as Bai Weiwei and Chen Liuying coordinate their stories, this matter can be characterized as settled."

Everyone followed her reasoning and understood the logic behind it.

But—

"What's the use of that?" Liang Xinhe said. "Can't we just present evidence directly to deny it?"

"We could, but there's still one person who hasn't come out yet," Liang Shi said. "Chen Liuying, who's been hiding behind Bai Weiwei all this time, is still staying out of it. And if we hammer them directly, this story loses its meaning."

Liang Xinhe: "?"

"What netizens like to see are twists and turns, big satisfying stories, the kind where evidence hits hard," Liang Shi said. Having worked in the entertainment industry for years, she knew better than anyone how deep these waters ran.

Sometimes, not participating directly didn't mean not knowing.

Her agent Sister Wang was a very capable person who had taken her from being unknown to becoming an actress with both popularity and reputation, while also maintaining a good name in the industry herself.

How many people she had dealt with and how many opponents she had played—Liang Shi basically knew it all.

In this circle, you couldn't have malicious intent toward others, but you absolutely had to guard against others' malicious intent toward you.

Sister Wang had always felt that she was too Buddhist¹, like a delicate white flower that couldn't withstand wind, afraid that when she went solo later, she'd be eaten alive without even bones left. So when secretly dealing with opponents and manipulating fan psychology, Sister Wang never avoided letting her see, and even wanted her to learn.

Usually she would just smile without saying anything. Only when Sister Wang lectured her earnestly several times would she retort: "No matter where I go, you'll still be my agent."

"I can't protect you for life," Sister Wang would say. "The roads in this circle are long if you say they're long—some people might walk them their whole lives. But they're also short if you say they're short—make one mistake and there's no way forward. You'd better learn. Those people have all eaten thousand-year ginseng fruit²—they're crafty as monkeys."

What Bai Weiwei had learned in her few years in the industry was far less than what Liang Shi had seen while following Sister Wang.

When Liang Shi said those words, it was as if Sister Wang was whispering earnestly in her ear.

Those forceful words from Sister Wang coming out of her mouth made her feel momentarily dazed.

If Sister Wang could see that she could now stand on her own, becoming the PR strategist for two major companies, she would probably be very gratified.

But there wasn't much time for her to feel sentimental and reminisce.

Liang Shi immediately got into state and explained to everyone: "While I'm revealing this information to Bai Weiwei, I'm also giving her psychological suggestion. With her current twisted psychology and towering hatred, she'll find someone to leak more material. Anyway, mixing truth and lies, her goal is for everyone to curse Xu Qingzhu, then ruin Minghui's reputation."

"This is too troublesome," Liang Xinhe frowned. "Let's just issue a lawyer's letter directly."

"No," Liang Shi said. "This is such a good opportunity. It's trending! Normally this would cost a lot of money."

Liang Xinhe: "...Our family doesn't lack that little bit."

"But using the opponent's money to promote our stuff is never wrong, right?" Liang Shi said. "Save what we can save."

Everyone: "...?"

Liang Shi didn't mind, and instead turned to Sally: "Post another Weibo. I'll send you the copy."

Then she lowered her head to edit the copy: [The previous Weibo was my mistake, sorry. I won't participate in this matter anymore.]

Sally frowned: "This won't work."

"It will," Liang Shi's gentle voice rang out in the office, looking at her with very determined eyes: "Trust me."

With an aura that naturally commanded submission.

Sally reluctantly posted that Weibo, and even added a wronged little expression at the end on her own initiative.

As soon as the Weibo was posted, the comment section was rapidly overrun again.

[So it's true then?]

[Slipping and kneeling this fast—are you afraid we won't buy your designed products?]

[Amazing, the master hits people, the lackey makes snide remarks.]

[Hitting people is definitely confirmed. It's been so long without issuing a lawyer's letter or PR statement.]

[Two major luxury companies! Even if Minghui has fallen, it was once a sun-never-sets empire. Tsk, this is definitely acknowledgment.]

[I'm really speechless. I originally really liked your designs, but now this whole thing has made me lose interest in buying.]

[...]

Sally handed her phone to Liang Shi, helplessly saying: "This place has almost become a garbage dump."

"It's all small stuff," Liang Shi said. "Let the public opinion ferment a bit more."

After Liang Shi finished speaking, she looked at Liang Xinhe: "Second brother, Dongheng's competitors include Changli, right?"

Liang Xinhe raised an eyebrow: "What for?"

Originally thinking that Liang Shi was just fooling around, Liang Xinhe was now gradually becoming interested in what she was doing.

He always felt it should be something big.

Footnotes:

¹ Buddhist: In Chinese internet slang, refers to someone who is very laid-back, non-competitive, and goes with the flow

² Thousand-year ginseng fruit: Reference to the magical fruit from "Journey to the West" that grants immortality; here meaning they're very experienced/cunning

Chapter 58-2

Liang Shi smiled slightly, "A few days ago when I was researching, I discovered that their company is in talks with Chen Liuying about becoming their spokesperson."

Liang Xinhe: "..."

"Have the relevant person in charge call their company's person responsible for this area. Don't be too direct about it, just subtly hint that Chen Liuying won't work, that she can't be used," Liang Shi said. "You should be quite proficient in this kind of verbal technique—I don't need to teach you, right?"

Liang Xinhe: "..."

He stared at Liang Shi, and after a moment took out his phone, couldn't help but smile, meeting Liang Shi's smiling eyes.

"You've got something," Liang Xinhe said as he went out to make the call.

The remaining people in the office watched her methodically arrange everything.

This included calling Zhao Ying to discuss which direction to steer the online public opinion.

Zhao Ying had extensive connections in the entertainment industry, but she had fashion brand endorsements and couldn't promote anything at this sensitive time.

However, she posted a photo with Zhao Xuning, with the caption: [Today's happy selfie! Dragging my busy cousin away for a moment to do some promotion.]

The extremely beautiful, coldly expressed Zhao Xuning was already wearing Minghui's latest necklace.

And it was very eye-catching.

Many people spontaneously began searching for information about Zhao Xuning's necklace, and finally discovered it was Minghui's new product.

Everyone: ...Instantly shattered.

The celebrity effect was displayed to the fullest at this moment.

However, many people also went to Zhao Ying's Weibo to attack her, saying she was making dirty money, that she was secretly protecting people, but they were all silenced by Zhao Ying's fans' powerful fighting ability.

When it came to fan fighting power, no one in the entertainment industry could compare to Zhao Ying and Yang Shuyan.

Zhao Ying's fans were usually Buddhist¹, either they wouldn't fight you, or if they fought, they'd fight until you were out of the entertainment industry.

Yang Shuyan's fans were ready to fight anytime, anywhere. Of course, they wouldn't fight nobodies—in their words, giving nobodies even one extra glance would be letting them leech off popularity.

So faced with absolute fighting power, those casual fans and Chen Liuying's fans weren't worth mentioning at all.

No one dared to provoke them.

Meanwhile, Minghui Jewelry's new product sales had begun to skyrocket. Being on trending searches meant visibility.

Currently, Minghui's company had limited funds. Xu Qingzhu was someone who strictly controlled product quality, so most of the capital was invested in the products themselves. The funds that could be allocated for marketing and promotion were pitifully small—they could only buy trending searches ranked 30th or lower.

But now it was different!

Top five trending searches, and Minghui's name occupied three of them.

All traffic delivered by their opponents!

Using other people's money to promote their own products—it couldn't be more satisfying!

Quite a few paid commenters were stirring up discussions, the trending page was refreshing rapidly. While some people were cursing, others were praising their product quality and stunning beauty.

So beautiful that it didn't even need words of praise—just posting one picture could amaze people enough to want to check the official website.

Driven by such popularity, autumn new product sales climbed steadily.

This wasn't the end—the most terrifying thing was that Yang Shuyan, who had no endorsement deals, waded into these muddy waters at this time.

She directly posted a giveaway post, giving away Minghui Jewelry's new necklace—the same style that Zhao Xuning was wearing around her neck.

At the same time, she commented: [A junior I haven't contacted in a long time has actually become a designer, must support her]

After Liang Shi saw this, she was shocked and asked Zhao Ying in confusion: "Sister Ying, did you do this?"

Zhao Ying: "...It wasn't me."

Lin Luoxi, who had been sitting quietly in the office, helplessly held her forehead and spoke up: "It was me."

Then she called Yang Shuyan, simple and direct: "Senior, thank you."

Yang Shuyan said from the other end: "You should have said earlier if you needed help. I can't help with other things, but this much I can do."

Lin Luoxi: "Got it, we're still discussing countermeasures here."

"Wait until this heat dies down before issuing the lawyer's letter," Yang Shuyan said. "The heat is high right now."

Lin Luoxi: "Mm, our strategist here said the same thing."

Liang Shi hadn't expected that Lin Luoxi actually knew Yang Shuyan, and that it was the kind of relationship where she could help unconditionally in chaos.

Liang Shi said in amazement: "You actually know Yang Shuyan."

"Mm," Lin Luoxi said. "High school senior."

Liang Shi's gaze seemed to glance over at Xu Qingzhu intentionally or unintentionally, as if thinking of something, but she didn't say anything and continued with her planning.

It had to be said that Yang Shuyan's firm promotional stance made the organic buzz even stronger.

Yang Shuyan's fans' purchasing power was no joke—it was genuinely strong.

So the backend orders exploded.

Currently, Minghui Jewelry was short of money, so Xu Qingzhu had decided early on not to use hunger marketing², and had divided products into several tiers.

The slightly cheaper tiers had already sold out, but there were still continuous pre-orders pouring in.

The internet was vast, with tens of millions to hundreds of millions of people online simultaneously. No matter how loud the cursing voices were, there were countless people staying silent.

And their main purchasing power came from those silent people.

The silent ones were often the majority.

In this environment, Liang Shi had Lin Luoxi also post a Weibo: [No explanation needed, justice will prevail.]

Not long after this Weibo was posted, it was also quickly overrun by netizens in the comments, and shortly after, Bai Weiwei also posted a Weibo.

As Chen Liuying's agent, her Weibo also had over 500,000 followers, and speaking out at such a critical moment meant her attitude represented Chen Liuying's attitude from the side.

Footnotes:

¹ Buddhist: In Chinese internet slang, refers to someone who is very laid-back, non-competitive, and goes with the flow

² Hunger marketing: A marketing strategy where companies intentionally create scarcity to increase demand and perceived value

Chapter 58-3

@Bai Weiwei: Hope there will be justice.

She posted a photo—it was Chen Liuying's hospital registration slip.

This was a direct confrontation.

Bai Weiwei was perhaps a cautious person. She knew that Xu Qingzhu's phone call was to trap her into saying something, so she was defensive with every sentence.

And after waiting so long, she still hadn't made any moves.

But her rage had consumed her rationality.

One misstep and she would take extreme measures.

This was exactly what Liang Shi was waiting for.

Not long after, Changli officially announced Chen Liuying as their spokesperson.

At this critical juncture, they didn't even need to buy trending searches—Chen Liuying's foolish fans directly pushed it to the front page.

Liang Xinhe said: "BARE had also been in contact with this person before, but was more inclined toward Chen Ling, who's the same type. Changli had always been hesitating, thinking her recent popularity wasn't enough. Now with this drama, they immediately finalized the contract and made the official announcement without stopping."

"I thought they could hold their ground, at least wait until tomorrow," Liang Xinhe looked at the official announcement poster on his phone, then exited.

Liang Shi chuckled lightly, "That's perfect, we can pit... help one person at a time."

Although she corrected herself in time, people still heard her intention.

Liang Shi casually edited the recording of Xu Qingzhu and Bai Weiwei's conversation just now, then told Xu Qingzhu to watch the computer—someone would send files over that needed to be saved immediately.

When Xu Qingzhu looked, the ID was "Liuying Mantian¹."

She didn't understand what files would be sent, until the other party sent a photo of Bai Weiwei and Chen Liuying kissing.

Along with photos of them holding hands and embracing that were sent one after another, the atmosphere was ambiguous to the extreme.

After Liang Shi finished all this, she finally turned her gaze to Zhou Yi'an.

She walked up to Zhou Yi'an, "Talk outside?"

Zhou Yi'an's hand that was poking the screen paused, "Let's just talk here."

"Really?" Liang Shi raised an eyebrow.

Zhou Yi'an pressed her lips together, then stood up and walked outside without saying a word.

Sally watched from the side with surging emotions, constantly telling Lin Luoxi: "So Alpha²!"

Lin Luoxi: "Who?"

Sally: "Both of them!"

Lin Luoxi disdainfully: "Go get your eyes checked."

Footnotes:

¹ Liuying Mantian: Literally means "fireflies filling the sky," likely a reference to Chen Liuying's name (Liuying means firefly)

² Alpha: Referring to the dominant, confident personality type from ABO (Alpha-Beta-Omega) dynamics, used here as slang to describe someone with strong, commanding presence

Chapter 58-4

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Zhou Yi'an and Liang Shi went up to the rooftop, where the wind was strong, blowing their hair into disarray.

Zhou Yi'an took out a cigarette from her pocket, no longer displaying her previous frivolousness. She looked at Liang Shi like looking at a stranger, and through layers of smoke, her entire person seemed unreal.

"What do you want from me?" Zhou Yi'an exhaled a puff of smoke before speaking.

Liang Shi also didn't have time to waste words with her, "Cheng Ran has already apologized to Xu Qingzhu, so where's your apology?"

"Which matter?" Zhou Yi'an asked.

"Huayue International." Liang Shi smiled with lips curved, emanating a dangerous aura with aggressive undertones that she never usually displayed. "You were the mastermind behind it all."

Liang Shi looked at her, "If I hadn't gone that day, what did you want to do?"

"There are no 'ifs'," Zhou Yi'an said. "The fact is that Xu Qingzhu is fine now."

"But she..." Liang Shi paused, then changed the topic, "Now it's time for you to apologize, isn't it?"

Zhou Yi'an chuckled lightly, "Liang Shi, do you love her this much? You remember and want to settle even grudges from so long ago?"

She didn't use that sickeningly sweet "baby" term of endearment, and her tone carried a hint of contempt.

But Liang Shi firmly said: "Yes."

"Then if I apologize," Zhou Yi'an looked at her, eyes staring tightly into her pupils as if trying to see into the depths of her soul, "can you return to how you were before? Give me back the original you."

Zhou Yi'an's tone was very light, but carried an inexplicable sense of oppression, "Give me back the you who didn't love Xu Qingzhu."

Liang Shi suddenly felt an indescribable feeling in her heart.

She looked at Zhou Yi'an.

For a long time, she heavily exhaled, "Sorry, I can't do that."

Zhou Yi'an extinguished her cigarette and casually waved away the smoke in front of her, "Then I can't do it either."

"What I'm asking you to do isn't much," Liang Shi said. "Cheng Ran said you have photos of Bai Weiwei drinking with clients¹. Can you take them out?"

Liang Shi knew that asking someone as high and mighty as Zhou Yi'an to bow her head and apologize was like asking for the moon, so she settled for the next best thing.

She didn't want to use such unseemly things to attack others.

But just in case.

If Bai Weiwei quieted down along with Chen Liuying after they released the recording, she would send these photos to Bai Weiwei as a warning, telling her not to behave like this in the future.

But if Bai Weiwei continued to test them, then Liang Shi's bottom line could descend to the same level as hers.

Zhou Yi'an glanced at her, "Why should I give them to you?"

Liang Shi pressed her lips together: "Don't people need to pay a price when they do wrong?"

"Not for me," Zhou Yi'an chuckled lightly. "Not for the previous you either."

She smiled with curved lips, her black denim jacket blown tight against her graceful body by the wind, "After all, we're world-destroying demon kings²."

Liang Shi looked at her and suddenly said earnestly: "Even world-destroying demon kings will bow their heads for someone."

For a long time.

The wind on the rooftop blew over this city's building complex, blew over the hurried pedestrians on the road.

Zhou Yi'an closed her eyes and said helplessly: "You're right."

They would.

And once they bowed their head once, they'd bow their head every time.

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What Zhou Yi'an sent to Liang Shi were just a few pictures of Bai Weiwei entering private rooms with those directors, actively drinking with them.

And none of them were from surveillance angles.

When the time came, Bai Weiwei wouldn't even have grounds to sue.

Liang Shi prepared all the evidence and just waited for Chen Liuying to come forward and respond to this matter.

After Changli announced their spokesperson, Chen Liuying's studio Weibo posted a collaborative post.

But Chen Liuying's personal Weibo had no activity whatsoever.

When the heat was about to die down, everyone had completely defaulted to believing that this matter was indeed Xu Qingzhu's doing.

The two major companies hadn't issued lawyer's letters, Xu Qingzhu herself hadn't spoken out, and her friend's statement was also incoherent—it was definitely confirmed.

At this time, Chen Liuying finally posted on Weibo: [It's a private matter, no big deal. Busy filming, don't want to take up public resources unnecessarily. Thank you for everyone's attention.]

—It's a private matter, no big deal.

Didn't that mean she was indeed hit?

Celebrity Weibos always posted such ambiguous content, because it would be filled in by fans' imagination.

After this Weibo was posted, fans directly went to attack Minghui Jewelry's official Weibo.

[Tell your young lady to go die, okay?]

[Is capital so great? Are there still human rights in this world?]

[Damn! I'm so angry! Tell your young lady to die!]

[...]

Chen Liuying's fans had foul mouths and directly escalated to personal attacks.

After Liang Shi saw this Weibo, she signaled that Xu Qingzhu could step forward.

So after a day of commotion, Xu Qingzhu directly tagged Bai Weiwei and Chen Liuying.

@Xu Qingzhu-Blanche: @Bai Weiwei @Chen Liuying, are you certain that I was the one who hit someone?

Footnotes:

¹ Drinking with clients: Refers to the practice in the entertainment industry where people (often women) are pressured to drink alcohol with directors, producers, or investors, often in private settings, sometimes as a form of sexual harassment or exploitation

² World-destroying demon kings: An exaggerated way to describe people who are rebellious, powerful, and don't follow conventional rules